



◀ The mojito, a combination of white rum, sugar, lime juice, soda and mint—started life as a cure for scurvy



▶ The Moscow Mule is one part vodka with two parts ginger beer served in a copper mug full of ice

90 |

Lama says that the dominant flavour in the mojito that one should be looking for is mint. “A mojito should be led by mint, followed by the balance of the lime and sugar.”

Another popular day drink is the Bloody Mary, which according to cocktail lore is named after British Queen Mary who was popularly known as ‘Bloody Mary’ because of her brutal and violent acts. The drink was, however, invented in a bar in Paris in the 1920s. A combination of vodka, tomato juice, Tabasco/Worcestershire sauce, black pepper and lemon, it is also considered a good hangover cure. Lama suggests that it should not be over-spiced and not overpowering with tomato juice.

Another cocktail with an interesting back story is the Moscow Mule. Next time you order it or see someone sipping a cocktail in a cop-

per mug, think of the three people, each figuring out a way to sell his/her excess stock. The cocktail was born in a Hollywood bar in 1941 when a Russian immigrant walked in with her stock of copper mugs looking for a buyer. At the Cock ‘n’ Bull bar she met Smirnoff owner John Martin, who was struggling to sell his vodka, and bar owner Jack Morgan, who couldn’t sell his new brand of ginger beer. The Moscow Mule which is one part vodka, two parts ginger beer, served in a copper mug full of ice was the perfect result of a collaboration between the three to sell their respective products, or so the story goes.

The beauty of cocktails is that they are open to interpretations and at the end of the day based on the skill of the bartender. Singapore-based rooftop cocktail bar Smoke & Mirrors has a cocktail menu inspired

by art. Sixteen paintings from the National Gallery Singapore are the inspiration behind each of the cocktails. For instance, you have a rum-based cocktail called Moves Like Jigger inspired by Ho Ho Ying’s painting Rhythm of Dance, another cognac-based cocktail called Breaking Storm is inspired by the 1839 painting Shipwreck in Storm.

Similarly, Angelina’s at the Sofitel Metropole Hotel in Hanoi has a cocktail menu inspired by people’s personalities. So you can order a drink called Charismatic which is a bourbon and red wine cocktail or Optimist which is a champagne and vodka cocktail.

The next time you’re sipping one of your favourite cocktails or a new one, say cheers to its back story. **BT**

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